

The Great Wooden Horse

The windswept shores of Troy stretch along a bright Aegean sea, where wooden ships with painted eyes lie beached on the long sand and a great city of honey-coloured walls stands proud on the hill above. For a long while two camps, the weary seafarers on the beach and the proud city behind its gates, have been caught in a tired old quarrel that neither truly wants. Across the wine-dark sea lies the long road home, full of wonders: a loyal old hound, a keeper of the winds, and lonely sea-singers on the rocks. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is clever, brave, and keeps faith with a friend. The grandest deeds are done not with spears but with a good idea and a kind heart, and the oldest quarrels often end with a single brave act of friendship.



The Great Wooden Horse

Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

For longer than anyone could properly remember, the two camps on the windswept shores of Troy had been caught in a tired old quarrel. Down on the long beach the seafarers lived among their tents and their wooden ships with painted eyes. Up on the hill the proud city stood behind its great honey-coloured walls, with its gates barred fast. Nobody could say how it had started, and the strange thing was that nobody on either side really wanted it any more. Both camps were weary to the bone, and both, in their secret hearts, longed for it simply to end.

Odysseus the Clever called the two of you to his side. He had a short curly beard and a kind, twinkling smile, and he turned a tiny carved horse over in his hands as he spoke. "I have had an idea," he said, "and it is a better one than any shouting across the sand. Let us build a great wooden horse, as tall as a house. But we shall not fill it with soldiers, as the old, sad stories might. We shall fill it with gifts and music and a hand of friendship, and roll it up to the gates as a happy surprise. A kind surprise can end a quarrel that a thousand cross words never could."

Into your hands he pressed three gifts: a basket of honey and figs, a ball of Penelope's thread, and a great spiral conch horn. "Remember," he said, "on these shores we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being clever, brave, and loyal to a friend."

What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Cleverness, Courage, or Loyalty?

Stop 1: Building the Horse

The builders had gathered great heaps of smooth wooden planks along the sand, but heaps of wood are not yet a horse. It had to stand tall and strong on its wheels, balanced so it would not wobble or topple, with a neat little door cut into one side.

The carpenters scratched their heads and looked to you. How many planks would each sturdy leg need? How should the curved pieces of the great barrel body be fitted so the whole thing balanced? Penelope's thread was just the tool for measuring a piece before it was cut, and careful counting would tell you exactly how many planks the builders must bring.

How could you build it so it stands straight and steady? Could you measure each piece with the thread? Could you count the planks out together and work out the balance? What is your plan?

When the pieces were measured, counted, and fitted together just so, the great wooden horse rose at last upon its wheels: tall, proud, and steady as the walls themselves. The whole beach broke into a cheer.

Stop 2: Filling It with Friendship

The horse was built, and its little side door stood open like a question. Now came the heart of Odysseus's idea: what should go inside? Not soldiers, and not anything frightening. The entire point was a gift, a surprise so kind that no shut gate could stay shut against it.

You looked over all the lovely things laid out along the sand: the basket of ripe figs and golden honey, garlands of bright flowers gathered from the hillside, and a small drum for making happy music.

Which things would make the kindest surprise? Which gifts whisper, "let us be friends at last"? Choose them together. There is truly no wrong answer here, only warmer ones.

When you had tucked the figs, the flower garlands, and the little drum safely inside, the great horse seemed to glow with welcome, like a present that can hardly wait to be opened. It was, beyond any doubt, the friendliest horse that the shores of Troy had ever seen.

Stop 3: The Surprise at the Gates

Slowly, and with many willing hands, you rolled the great horse up the long hill to the gates of the city. High on the honey-coloured walls the city folk gathered to watch, wary and weary, and the gates stayed firmly shut. For one long moment your heart thumped in your chest.

But this was never a fight, and the horse was never a trick. It was a gift. All you had to do was show the weary city that it came from friends.

What could you do to show them you come in friendship? You carry the conch horn to sound a warm and welcoming hello across the walls. You could swing open the horse's door and share the sweet figs. What do you try?

When you lifted the conch horn and sounded its warm, round note, and then opened the little door, out spilled figs and flowers and the merry tap of the drum. The watchful faces on the walls froze, then softened, then broke into astonished smiles. With a great groan of old timber, the gates of the proud city swung open at last.

The Long Quarrel Ends

Down came the city folk from their high walls, and up came the seafarers from the beach, and they met in the middle of the hill, shy and uncertain at first. Then one hand offered a fig to another. Someone tapped the little drum. Somebody laughed, and the laughter spread until the whole hillside rang with it.

Together, side by side, the two camps spread a great feast upon the grass, as though the long quarrel had been no more than a bad dream now happily forgotten. Far out on the gentle, glittering water, Thetis the Sea-Mother raised her face from the waves and smiled to see it. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your cleverness, with your courage, and above all with your loyalty to a friend. The oldest quarrel of all had ended, not with spears, but with a single kind surprise. Well done, heroes of the windswept shores of Troy.

The Story in Pictures



Two small heroes and friendly seafarers building a great wooden horse on the beach, measuring planks with a thread and fitting the pieces together.



Two small heroes filling the open belly of a great wooden horse with baskets of figs, flower garlands and a little drum, smiling as they work.



A great garlanded wooden horse at the tall gates of a honey-coloured city wall, wary city folk peeking down, two small heroes below sounding a conch and offering figs.



The two camps feasting together on the beach at sunset around the garlanded wooden horse, seafarers and city folk sharing figs, a clever kindly sea-captain smiling among them.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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